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Basically as our nuclear power programme grows, we require to set up adequate reprocessing capacity. We would not be investing any more than what we would have done anyway.

Q. But what are the main gains we can expect out of the deal?

A. It pains me when people say we would get superior technology because of the deal. Our reactors are world class. In the long term, with our three-stage programme and strong fundamentals, it will open up the huge energy potential for India. It is important because we hold one-third of the world's thorium and given the global energy crisis, it will be foolhardy if we sacrifice this and run after a few 1,000 MWs plants from outside.

Q. So why have a deal then?

A. Our indigenous programme involves a sequential technology development. Even if you try to accelerate that, there are limits to it. So our problem is short term and how to meet the energy demand right now. The agreement allows us to proceed unhindered with our own long-term domestic power programme and our military and R and D requirements for national interests. At the same time, the deal allows us access to nuclear technology from both the US and the others to meet our short-term power needs. More importantly, it also eliminates the isolation we faced so far.

Q. What are the targets you are fixing for nuclear power generation?

A. There are several steps that are yet to be taken and so I would actually wait to see what happens. But one thing is sure. If all these things work out, it will certainly be a paradigm shift in the short run. We already have a programme of 20,000 MW by 2020 which included a provision for 8,000 MW from imported units. So this agreement would allow us to meet that schedule. That's the baseline but in reality it could be much more.

dress Parliament laying down the redlines that the Government would not cross. It would be a blessing in disguise, for he would later tell Bush, "I have my own Congress" and insist that the July 18 and March 2 accords that they had reached should not be violated. Manmohan cleverly got BJP and Left to make these two pacts the benchmark to judge whether he had delivered.

By June, eight rounds of torturous negotiations had not provided an agreement on certain key provisions. These included the right to reprocess spent fuel from the imported reactors and immunising the nuclear power programme from any breakdowns in the agreement by guaranteeing a strategic fuel reserve for its lifetime. The two leaders would again end up "carrying the pails up the hill personally," as Robert Blackwill, former US ambassador to India, put it.

When Manmohan met Bush briefly for a pull-aside meeting at the G-8 meeting in Germany, he told the US President that he expected him to keep his word. He recalls, "Bush listened

guards that would ensure that there was no diversion or leakage. US Undersecretary of State Nicholas Burns, a key negotiator, describes that as "the fundamental turning point".

The strategic fuel reserve issue proved as contentious. Indians were looking for cast-iron guarantees that would immunise the working of the power plants against any exigencies. There was an additional problem. The Hyde Act had a right-to-return clause in the event of the agreement breaking down. US Congressmen had insisted on incorporating the provision in a bid to make India pay dear if it decided to conduct another nuclear test.

During the negotiations, the Indian team was clear. There should be a categorical statement that its nuclear weapons programme would be allowed to proceed without any interference from the US. As regards nuclear testing, India had a unilateral moratorium but retained its sovereign right to conduct it in the supreme national interest. The right to test would in no way figure in the negotiations.

THE PRIME MINISTER cleverly got the BJP and the Left to agree that the redlines drawn in Parliament should be the benchmark on how he should be judged.

carefully and took notes in long hand." Bush then told his National Security Adviser Steve Hadley to follow up with his Indian counterpart Narayanan. Hadley and Narayanan had always got along well and they agreed to meet in July to sort out the tangle and come out with a mutually-agreeable 123 bilateral agreement that would put into legalese what the Hyde Act had stipulated.

In the third week of July, when Narayanan was to lead the team to the final round of negotiations, Manmohan told him, "You know what the redlines are and whatever the commitments I made to Parliament, make sure that it is met." Hadley also seemed to have clear instructions from Bush to iron out the kinks and proved most helpful during the weeklong negotiations.

To crack the reprocessing issue, the Indian negotiators decided to invert the problem and address American concerns. They proposed setting up a separate national reprocessing facility under the most stringent IAEA safe-

In the finalised 123 Agreement, the two sides built up a multi-layered process of review to avoid an immediate cessation of the agreement in such an event. When the two sides reached a consensus on the contentious issues, Narayanan called up Manmohan and said, "There is room for optimism that we have an agreement."

Manmohan is confident that he has met all the commitments he had made to Parliament. But the Left and BJP don't think so. The prime minister is prepared to battle it out in the House. There is still a while before the deal becomes operational. India would now have to negotiate a safeguards agreement with the IAEA, the NSG would have to give its unconditional clearance and the US Congress would have to vote again to ratify the 123 Agreement. Manmohan is determined to see the deal through. As he said in the Lok Sabha, "When future generations look back, they will come to acknowledge the significance of the deal." ■

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